

with people he knew in several churches in town, recommending her services.

With the girls' help and later a part-time assistant, she was able to get her business off the ground. Beth and her sister found themselves going from having fun family times and stylish made-to-order outfits to wearing clothes from the thrift store and clearance racks, and spending vacation time and special days cooking and serving others for *their* special events.

The family struggled, and there never seemed to be quite enough money. Beth felt they were now different from "other families." "Other families" went on vacation. "In other families, the kids don't have to help their mother cook." And to their dismay, the houses in their area were reassessed, and the property taxes suddenly skyrocketed. Mrs. Kramer felt she could no longer afford the house, so she put it up for sale, and the family moved to an apartment. Beth couldn't help thinking, "Other families live in houses."

Because she didn't want her girls to bear her burdens, Mrs. Kramer kept the state of the family finances to herself. Beth and Nancy were provided for, but Beth always felt like there was never enough, and that she couldn't ask for or expect extras. Though she meant well, Mrs. Kramer, in her desire to keep the girls from worry, never taught them how to handle money.

Having a career in catering meant Mrs. Kramer could arrange her schedule to spend time with her girls, and the modest business made it possible to get by through Beth's senior year of high school. After that, she found a job at a big-box store, a position with benefits that paid well enough and even offered a retirement plan. Beth's older sister, Nancy, had gone to college for nursing on state grants and student loans, and was now happily working in a hospital in western Pennsylvania.

Beth lived at home for two years while attending community college. She knew she didn't want to go into debt for an education, so she worked at a home improvement store and paid for her classes herself. She only took a few classes at a time, though, because she